Merchant boats would have plied the Ganga, especially between Kausambi, Kashi and Pataliputra (modern Patna). There were ocean-going ships as well. The legend of prince Vijaya in the Mahavamsa suggests coastal trade links along the Bay of Bengal extending from Bengal to Sri Lanka. Both the Uttara Path and the Dakshina Path would have been busy highways, with the people plying these trade routes carrying not just goods but also ideas, because this was also a time of great intellectual expansion. The philosophies of the Upanishads, Mahavira and Gautam Buddha are all products of this milieu.

The Buddha was born in Kapilavastu (on the Indo–Nepal border) but he attained enlightenment at Bodh Gaya, just south of the old Magadhan capital of Rajgir. However, he did not deliver his first sermon in Bodh Gaya, the nearby towns and villages or even in the royal capital of Rajgir. Instead, he headed west to Varanasi (also called Kashi). Why did he go all the way to Varanasi to spread his message?

According to historian Vidula Jayaswal, this was a natural choice since Varanasi was an important place for the exchange of both goods and ideas because it stood at the crossroads between the Uttara Path and a highway that came down from the Himalayas and then continued south as the Dakshina Path. In some ways, this remains true to this day as the east–west National Highway 2 meets the north–south National Highway 7 at Varanasi. The latter then runs all the way down to the southern tip of India. The alignment of the modern north–south highway runs somewhat east of the ancient trade route but it is amazing how the logic of India's transport system has remained the same. Even when the British built the railways in the nineteenth century, they used Mughalsarai—just outside Varanasi—as the nerve-centre of the railway network.

When the Buddha went there in the sixth century BC, Varanasi was already a large urban settlement built on the Ganga. The city's name is derived from the fact that it was built between where the Varuna and the Asi streams flow into the sacred river. The Varuna is still a discernible stream but, sadly, the Asi has been reduced to a polluted municipal drain.